

CONGRESS'S COMEBACK STRATEGY

The Congress's Delhi election strategy focuses on reclaiming the Muslim and Dalit vote, attacking AAP's governance, introducing targeted welfare schemes and fielding strategic candidates

- **REBUILDING VOTER BASE:** The Congress aims to regain the lost Muslim and Dalit support through micro-campaigns, emphasising historical commitments to minority welfare, secularism and social justice, while highlighting AAP's perceived failures in these areas
- **GOING SOLO:** Breaking ties with AAP to contest independently reflects the party's plan to reclaim its voter base, targeting key constituencies and rejuvenating the morale of the grassroots Congress worker
- **FOCUSED FREEBIES:** Welfare programmes such as the Pyari Didi Yojana and Jeevan Raksha Yojana, along with targeted financial and healthcare benefits, form the cornerstone of the Congress's promises to woo Delhi voters
- **ATTACKING AAP ON CORRUPTION:** The Congress is leveraging high-profile controversies like the 'Liquorgate' scandal, the 'Sheesh Mahal' controversy and resource mismanagement allegations to undermine AAP's governance narrative and challenge its credibility
- **STRATEGIC CANDIDATE SELECTION:** The early announcement of candidates, fielding experienced leaders and selectively including defectors aim to project strength, though internal dissent over these choices could pose challenges

Severing ties with AAP is a calculated move by the Congress, which sees regaining its lost voter base from AAP as essential for a comeback in Delhi

ters, Delhi has around 1.5 million slum voters who account for a substantial 10 per cent of the total vote. The Lokniti-CSDS post-poll surveys in Delhi showed that 61 per cent of the poorest voted for AAP in the 2020 elections. The BJP has got the RSS to send out teams for a door-to-door appeal to all voters in these areas. The party's game plan is to gain 15-20 per cent in these clusters. It is also banking on bagging a substantial percentage of the votes of the middle class, which constitutes 45 per cent of the electorate. The middle-class voters, especially in the more well-to-do colonies, are upset with Kejriwal for the poor quality of roads, garbage collection and for failing to clean up the Yamuna, lapses that the BJP is tom-tomming across the town.

THE CONGRESS'S DILEMMA

The 2025 Delhi election is a critical moment for the Congress, especially after recent defeats in Haryana and Maharashtra. Reviving its fortunes in Delhi is not only crucial for the party's revival, but also for reclaiming its place in the Opposition narrative. With rising questions about its relevance within the INDIA Opposition bloc, the stakes are higher than ever. Once the unchallenged ruler of Delhi for three consecutive terms under Sheila Dikshit from 1998 to 2013, the party has since experienced a precipitous decline. The past three assembly elections have been disastrous, with the Congress failing to win even a single seat in both 2015 and 2020. The party's vote share plunged to 9.68 per cent in 2015 and to a mere 4.26 per cent in 2020.

Sandeep Dikshit, the Congress candidate fighting Kejriwal in the New Delhi constituency, often invokes his mother Sheila Dikshit's reign in his campaign, portraying it as a model era of development. "People still remember how good things were during Sheila Dikshit's time," he says. During one of his door-to-door outreaches in the constituency, Dikshit is accompanied by a handful of party loyalists, their enthusiasm unable to mask the painfully underwhelming nature of the exercise. Energy or crowds, they are conspicuous by their absence. The residents, he claims, are disillusioned with the current state of affairs. "People want change," Dikshit insists. The Congress has also joined the freebie bandwagon. Dikshit is unfazed by the allegation that the Congress is the BJP's "B-team". "Was AAP BJP's B-team in Haryana, Uttarakhand, Gujarat?" he retorts.

THE I.N.D.I.A DIVIDE

Despite being part of the INDIA coalition, the Congress and AAP have decided to contest independently in Delhi. This decision has created a triangular battle, with the BJP as the third major contender. Several INDIA partners, including the Trinamool Congress (TMC), Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), have thrown their weight behind AAP, deepening the existential crisis for the Congress. A poor showing could further diminish its influence within the coalition and weaken its national standing.

The decision to sever ties with AAP reflects a calculated move by the Congress, which sees regaining its lost voter